Queer Algorithmic Aesthetics and Digital Countercultures

By Philippe Beauchemin

An Introduction ----------

Aesthetics: “the term ‘aesthetic’ has come to designate, among other things, a kind of object, a kind of judgment, a kind of attitude, a kind of experience, and a kind of value” (Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, 2026)

Queer aesthetics

- Worldbuilding
- Norm-breaking (or “queering”)

+ algorithmic aesthetics

Digital culture

+ counterculture

- Digital communities
- Communication: codes, oppositional decoding

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Fantasy & Worldbuilding in the Face of Oppression

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"Technopatriarchy can be understood as the convergence of patriarchal logics with digital architectures of control. It does not merely regulate representation; it encodes which bodies are rendered audible, desirable, or disposable through classificatory systems, metrics, and content policies"

(Srnicek and Wajcman from Alaminos-Fernández et al, 2026)

Theoretical Foundation:

- Oppression – Liberation: tension
- Fantasy: a coping mechanism in the age of modernity (Tolkien, 1947)

Contemporary Queer Technofeminist Reading:

- The Secondary World: queer desires
- *Glitch Feminism*: hacking the tools, exploiting the "glitch" (Russell, 2020)
- Aesthetic = category: queerness evades categorization – look to *The Cyborg Manifesto* (Haraway, 1985)

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Queering Code and Space

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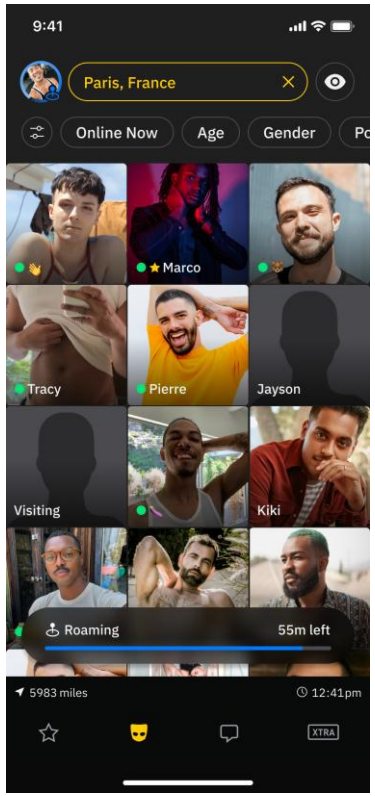
"... code/space surrounds us in the mutual constitution of software and the spatiality of everyday life. The effort to queer code/space here helps us rethink the co-production of code and space through the lens of everyday trans, and gay and non-heterosexual male lives and a rigorous application of queer theory."

(Kitchin and Dodge from Gieseking, 2017)

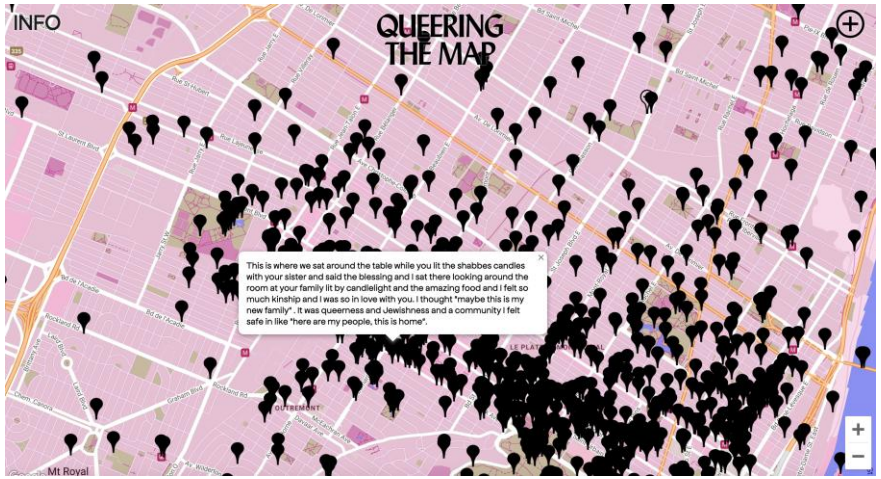
Cruising Utopia: "Queerness is that thing that lets us feel that this world is not enough, that indeed something is missing." (Munoz from Russell, 2020)

Digital translation of invisible encounters, spaces
Case study: Grindr vs *Queering the Map*

Grindr
Dark UI
Aesthetics of attractiveness



Queering the Map (Larochelle, 2017-ongoing)
Optimism
Aesthetics of collectivity



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Games and Social Media

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Avatars

Glitch Feminism: avatars and social media profiles can be used to express an alternate, desired, version of the self in the digital world (Russell, 2020)

- Bodies
  - Modding algorithms for body customization in The Sims*
  - "Skins" in Fortnite, e.g.
  - Embodied experiences in Vrchat, Rec Room
- Profiles (social media)
  - Allow for digital communities to form around markers



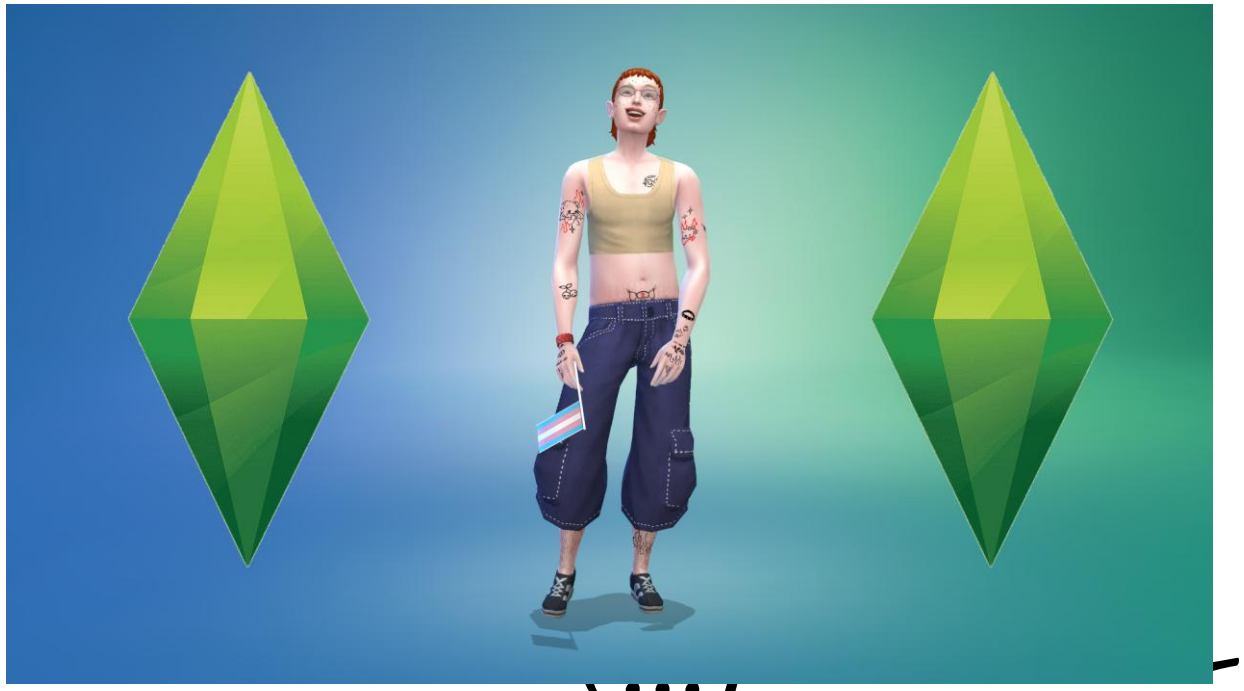
Indie Games and Machinima

Exploiting and subverting algorithmic concepts and paradigms:

Virtu•iel by Amélie Barrette and Laurence Wells (Barrette and Wells, 2025)



Fig I.1 :::: *Dys4ia* (2012) by Anna Anthropy, arguably the best-known video game from the queer games avant-garde



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"The growth of the queer games avant-garde also has notable implications for contemporary queer art-making beyond video games. These games sit at the avant-garde of interactive media as well as at the avant-garde of games. They are regularly shown in galleries and other fine arts spaces; they are also increasingly moving into settings associated with the performing arts."

“In this way, the queer games avant-garde is pushing the boundaries of how queerness is presented in digital and playful media art more broadly. Whether we see the effects of the queer games avant-garde as a sea change or a landslide, whether we are interested in making video games ‘better’ or simply queerer, this much is true: following the work of the queer games avant-garde, the cultural and artistic landscape of games will never be the same.”

(Ruberg, 2020)

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Sound and Music

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Sound: Worldbuilding, Voice Modifiers and Visibility

- Case study: SOPHIE
  - Worldbuilding with experimental sound design, *Immaterial* (SOPHIE, 2023)
- Gender play as a function of voice modifier algorithms
  - Hyperfeminization (Kim Petras, Grimes)
  - Hypermasculinization (Sofi Tukker)
- Club/underground scene digital culture
  - Hyperpop
  - Ballroom: hypervisibility (Madonna, fashion)
  - Kink/fetish (Cobrah)



Music: Lyrics as Resistance

- Case study: Arca
  - the lyric as an «affective infrastructure,» a text that organises feeling while resisting algorithmic capture (Alaminos-Fernández et al, 2026)



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